

DISCOVERING Tamil Nadu's Wild Side

From the lush forests to its long coastline, Tamil Nadu is brimming with wildlife, making the state a top destination for nature lovers.



Tamil Nadu's rich wildlife owes its existence to several factors. These include a diverse topography, conducive climate and ample vegetation. The varying environs support both dry and moist deciduous forests and the Government of Tamil Nadu has set up several national parks and wildlife and bird sanctuaries across the state to protect its biodiversity. Tamil Nadu's lush and varied habitats range from coastal to hilly, and some are even biodiversity hotspots, supporting an astonishing variety of fauna.

The state is known for the diversity of its mammals, including the tiger, Indian elephant, Nilgiri tahr and lion-tailed macaque. There's a wide variety of tree-dwelling mammals, notable among them being the slender loris. In October 2022, Tamil Nadu notified India's first slender loris sanctuary. The Kadavur Slender Loris Sanctuary is coming up in Karur and Dindigul districts and will cover an area of 11,806 hectares.

Located in the Nilgiris, the Mudumalai National Park is one of India's oldest protected areas and is part of the Nilgiri Biosphere Reserve. The park's tropical and subtropical moist broad leaf forests host several important mammals, including tiger, leopard, jungle cat, Indian wild dog, sloth bear, Indian elephant, gaur, and so on.

Set in the eponymous mountain range in the Western Ghats in Theni District, Megamalai Wildlife Sanctuary boasts pristine evergreen jungles lying at a height of 1,500 metres above sea level. Home to species like gaur, tiger, leopard, Indian brown mongoose, Indian elephant and Jerdon's palm civet, and birds like Oriental honey buzzard, great pied hornbill and pied thrush, it is a nature lover's delight.

Other noteworthy wildlife areas in Tamil Nadu include Guindy National Park in Chennai, which is one of the few national parks which is set inside a city; the Anaimalai Tiger Reserve, home to several endemic bird species, rare amphibians and reptiles, and hundreds of butterfly species; the Mukurthi National Park near Ooty, which is home to the Nilgiri tahr; and the Kalakkad Mundanthurai Tiger Reserve; which is set in the rainforests of the Western Ghats and is home several important animal species.

On the coastal side, the Gulf of Mannar Marine National Park is a protected area comprising 21 islets and coral reefs in the Gulf of Mannar. Lying off the coast of Tamil Nadu, between Thoothukudi and Dhanushkodi, the park has the dugong as its flagship mammal. There are dolphins and whales as well. Fish include butterfly fish, parrotfish, clown fish, etc. Olive Ridley and Green Turtles can also be spotted here.

Tamil Nadu is also home to several sanctuaries dedicated to birds. Some prominent ones are Pulicat Lake Bird Sanctuary, Vedanthangal Bird Sanctuary, Vettangudi Bird Sanctuary, Karikili Bird Sanctuary and Chitrangudi Bird Sanctuary. Apart from resident species, these sanctuaries attract a wide variety of migratory birds in winter, including flamingoes, pelicans and storks.

The state of Tamil Nadu is truly a biodiversity hotspot and a must-visit destination for wildlife enthusiasts.

